

YOU ARE BEING SOLD

How big data analytics, social media engines and everything you love about the Internet is used to track your every move, repackage you as eyeballs and sell you to the highest bidder

Jayesh Shinde

In the late '80s and early '90s as most of us were introduced to the digital era and grew up using a computer, our understanding of data was largely mathematical in nature. An arbitrary construct of 1s and 0s, data was an innocent consequence of our indulgence with the PC in its early days. It was something you marvelled at and were fascinated with.

Back then data was impersonal, immaterial, frivolous, something we never thought of twice. It was either a result of a calculation or that which was produced at work or generated in a closed, controlled lab experiment. It was fun, dealing with this data, and we started generating more of it as the digital world started expanding and making in-roads into all forms of our life. As computers swept through industries, ringing in wave after wave of digitisation from one industry to another, data generation reached new heights. And once the Internet Age took off, there was no looking back. From downloading software to music and movies and a variety of digital thingamajigs, our appetite for data knew no bounds. And as the data pipes

that connected us to the rest of the world got fatter and better adept at handling greater chunks of data traffic, it flamed the inferno of data we dealt with on a daily basis. Before we could pause to get a sense of the road we were embarking upon, without realising it, data started to make greater in-roads into our lives. It started to dominate our existence.

Welcome to Big (bad?) Data: It's here to stay

Circa 2014, data in the digital age is almost synonymous with who and what we are. It defines and characterises us, and is grand

in scale and volume. It's like an overwhelming and out-of-control tsunami. The narrative around data has evolved from consumption to self-production. Equipped with camera phones and tablets that feature Internet connectivity, built-in GPS and other gizmo wizardry, we can easily generate more content than we've ever been able to in our history as a species. In fact, all the data generated and stored by mankind till 2003 went on to be doubled by 2010.

The Internet and World Wide Web has made publishing, posting, saving and retrieving data easier than a wink. Sharing

REALLY BIG DATA FACTS

- IDC estimates that by 2020, business transactions – including B2B and B2C – on the internet will reach 450 billion per day.
- Walmart handles more than 1 million customer transactions every hour. This is imported into several databases, estimated to contain more than 2.5 petabytes of data.
- In 2008, Google was processing 20 petabytes (20,000TB) of data per day.
- AT&T has a database that's 312 TB in size and includes 1.9 trillion phone call records.
- 30 billion pieces of content are shared on Facebook every month.
- Over 100 hours of video content is uploaded to YouTube every minute.